Red Hat

Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS)

Assistant Secretary for Technology Policy (ASTP)

Health Technology Ecosystem

Request for Information # CMS-0042-NC

Due Date: June 16, 2025

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Introduction

This document is a response to the CMS Health Technology Ecosystem Request for Information (RFI). It details Red Hat's qualifications and experience in supporting digital health products, particularly for the health care industry. The response addresses CMS's inquiry about stimulating developer interest, data access, digital identity, technical standards, data exchange, and includes recommendations based on Red Hat's expertise in open-source and hybrid cloud solutions, emphasizing the increasing trend and costs of IT overhauls in health systems. We are technology partners to policy and consulting organizations that will offer their approach as well.

Red Hat provides comprehensive support for digital health products tailored for patient care by addressing the unique demands of healthcare IT, including stringent compliance, data security, and the need for modern, agile platforms. An example of this is the Boston Children's Hospital ChRIS system, where we provide foundational open-source technologies like Red Hat OpenShift Container Platform and Red Hat OpenStack. Our expertise enabled the containerization and automation of medical image analysis plugins, making complex research software easily accessible and scalable for clinicians. This collaboration fostered an open-source community, facilitated high-performance processing (reducing analysis times from hours to minutes), and extended ChRIS's capabilities to integrate Artificial Intelligence (AI) workloads, as seen with projects like COVID-Net and the piloting of Red Hat OpenShift AI for improved diagnostic accuracy.

Red Hat's solutions enable healthcare organizations to transform IT with a focus on patient care and data access, leveraging core products like Red Hat OpenShift as a flexible and consistent application platform for hybrid and multi-cloud environments. This supports modernization of traditional systems and the development of AI-powered solutions, which are critical for processing vast amounts of integrated, curated data to gain insights, improve decision-making, and even achieve compliance with new regulations like the CMS Interoperability and Prior Authorization Final Rule.

Red Hat Trusted Application Pipeline tools are being used by federal agencies to improve software supply chain integrity. This ensures that software deployed in their environments are free from malicious code, continuously monitored, and compliant with federal standards

Specifically for beneficiaries, Red Hat's technology supports the infrastructure for digital tools that can help seniors manage chronic conditions, access care efficiently, and make informed health choices. This is achieved through:

Secure Data Management: Red Hat safeguards sensitive patient data (ePHI) with robust security features built into Red Hat Enterprise Linux and Red Hat OpenShift. These include system hardening, encryption at rest (e.g., LUKS, self-encrypting drives, Red Hat OpenShift Data Foundation encryption), encryption in transit (TLS/mTLS), and strict access controls such

as SELinux and OpenShift Security Context Constraints. Red Hat also offers HIPAA-qualified online services and provides compliance guidance which is critical for handling Medicare data.

The latest release, Red Hat Enterprise Linux 10, introduces advanced security capabilities, including early adoption of NIST-standardized post-quantum cryptography (PQC). These quantum-resistant features help the healthcare organization and CMS prepare for future threats like "harvest now, decrypt later" attacks, aligning with evolving federal mandates, such as FISMA and NIST SP 800-53. Additionally, Red Hat Enterprise Linux 10 enhances container security and integrates the AI-powered Lightspeed management tool, strengthening CMS's cybersecurity posture while improving operational efficiency and risk mitigation across healthcare systems.

Quantum capabilities to help modernize identity verification on Medicare.gov with a secure, scalable, and compliant foundation for sensitive user authentication processes. With enhanced quantum-resilient cryptography, Red Hat Enterprise Linux helps protect against emerging threats posed by quantum computing, future-proofing the site's encryption standards. Its built-in support for FIPS 140-3 validated modules and advanced SELinux policies ensures compliance with stringent federal security mandates, while containerization and automation capabilities streamline deployment and maintenance of identity verification services at scale. Together, these features enable Medicare.gov to verify user identities more securely and efficiently, while maintaining trust and regulatory alignment in a rapidly evolving digital landscape.

Interoperability and Data Flow: Today, health data is gathered from many sources in varied formats, often without shared meaning across researchers, clinicians, and other users. Among many barriers, non-harmonized data hinders users from identifying best practices in data extract, transform, and load (ETL) or "cleaning" processes, research data uses, rapid RWE development, care delivery science, and real-time clinical decisions. Rather than testing hypotheses, studying correlations, performing analyses, and deriving results, inordinate manual resources are devoted to ETL, mapping, and harmonization tasks to prepare data for analysis. This toil is not only costly, it requires third-party intervention, privacy risks, and produces additional barriers to novel RWE discovery. The federal government spends greater than $100 billion each year mapping legacy EHR data with COTS systems, yet still fails to achieve Semantic Data Harmonization results.

Red Hat solutions enable better connectivity across the organization through data consolidation and application integration, facilitating the secure flow of health information that is often siloed, aligning with CMS's goal of a patient-centric, digital healthcare system.

AI and Automation for Efficiency: Unlike other providers, Red Hat is uniquely positioned to support AI workloads with an open, hybrid cloud-native platform that supports innovation across *any environment*—on-premises, in the cloud, or at the edge.

With Red Hat AI technologies like OpenShift AI and Red Hat Enterprise Linux AI, organizations gain the flexibility to build, deploy, and scale AI models using open standards, while avoiding vendor lock-in. Red Hat's support for digital healthcare efficiency combines Red Hat AI, Red

Hat AI Inference Server, and RAG to significantly enhance AI and automation efficiency by uniting enterprise-grade scalability, cost-effective performance, and intelligent output generation. Red Hat AI, built on Red Hat OpenShift, provides a secure and flexible platform for developing, deploying, and managing AI models across hybrid environments - such as when interacting with other federal agencies - streamlining the entire lifecycle with automation and governance while avoiding vendor lock-in.

Red Hat's open hybrid cloud strategy and AI portfolio provides the flexibility to run AI applications *anywhere* you need them.

Red Hat AI Interference Server optimizes deep learning models to run efficiently on standard CPUs, eliminating the need for costly GPUs, while delivering high-throughput, low-latency inference—ideal for both data center and edge deployments. RAG enhances this by enabling AI systems to retrieve real-time, external knowledge to ground responses in relevant, up-to-date information, which minimizes hallucinations and improves generative output accuracy and reliability. Healthcare organizations and CMS can ensure that their RAG-powered applications deliver fast, accurate, and cost-effective responses, even as they scale to handle a large volume of queries and complex Large Language Model (LLM) workloads.

Together, these technologies deliver a high-performance, cost-effective, and intelligent AI ecosystem that enhances collaboration, accelerates decision-making, and reduces infrastructure demands.

Empowering Healthcare with Unmatched Cloud Flexibility: Red Hat's open hybrid cloud platform puts healthcare organizations and CMS in complete control—letting them securely run protected health information (PHI) workloads on-premises and/or in private clouds, while effortlessly managing non-sensitive workloads across hybrid and multi-cloud environments. This unparalleled flexibility breaks free from vendor lock-in, enabling tailored infrastructure strategies that maximize security, ensure compliance, and optimize costs. By delivering secure, scalable, and automated open-source solutions, Red Hat drives healthcare modernization, helping providers and payers build a resilient, future-ready digital foundation that elevates care quality and expands access for Medicare beneficiaries.

Red Hat OpenShift is being used to modernize the back-end systems of a federal marketplace. As part of a multi-year effort, Red Hat and partners delivered container-based, compliant infrastructure to support secure and scalable operations for a federal marketplace.

Background

As a technology vendor, Red Hat is exceptionally well-qualified to support digital health products for Medicare beneficiaries, based on our strong market standings, robust compliance capabilities, and extensive industry acknowledgments. As a leader in enterprise open source, Red Hat's foundational platforms like Red Hat Enterprise Linux and Red Hat OpenShift underpin secure and scalable digital health solutions, enabling organizations to transform IT,

modernize legacy systems, and develop AI-powered applications crucial for patient care and data management for future generations.

Red Hat's commitment to healthcare compliance is paramount; it supports stringent regulations such as HIPAA by providing HIPAA-qualified online services (like specific configurations of Red Hat OpenShift Dedicated, ROSA, OpenShift API Management, and OpenShift Data Foundation) for which it is prepared to act as a business associate, allowing covered entities to build secure PHI-compliant applications. This includes providing validated and supported compliance automation profiles and tools like Ansible Playbooks with HIPAA content.

Red Hat's industry acknowledgments, including numerous Red Hat Innovation Awards given to customers for groundbreaking use of open source in digital transformation and hybrid cloud, highlight our success in helping healthcare organizations (like Guidehouse and VA preventing veteran suicide with OpenShift AI, and others streamlining operations) achieve significant impact. Red Hat's market leadership in enterprise Linux, containers, AI and automation further solidifies our ability to deliver the reliable, secure, and interoperable digital health infrastructure required for Medicare beneficiaries.

Acknowledgements from Industry Analysts

Red Hat consistently receives strong accolades from leading industry analysts like IDC, Forrester, and Gartner, underscoring its market leadership and ability to deliver impactful enterprise solutions.

From IDC (International Data Corporation), Red Hat is frequently recognized as a Leader in key areas, such as the IDC MarketScape: Worldwide Multicloud and Hybrid Cloud Management with Automation. This highlights Red Hat's strong capabilities in AI, hybrid cloud, edge computing, third-party integration, and Infrastructure as Code, with specific mention of Red Hat Ansible Automation Platform's leadership in IT automation. IDC studies have also shown impressive ROI for Red Hat's training and overall solutions, with a notable 365% three-year ROI for Red Hat training due to increased staff competency, higher productivity, and faster deployment.

Forrester Research consistently positions Red Hat as a Leader in its influential "Forrester Wave" reports. Notably, Red Hat OpenShift has been recognized as a Leader in The Forrester Wave™: Multicloud Container Platforms, receiving high scores for its current offering, strategy, and market presence. Forrester acknowledges Red Hat's pace of innovation, flexibility in cloud offerings, enterprise reach, and robust support for AI/ML and security features.

Similarly, Gartner frequently places Red Hat in the Leader's quadrant of its renowned "Magic Quadrant" reports. Red Hat has been named a Leader in the Gartner® Magic Quadrant™ for Cloud Application Platforms and the Gartner® Magic Quadrant™ for Container Management. These recognitions validate Red Hat OpenShift's strength as a comprehensive application platform, emphasizing its ability to accelerate application development and deployment across diverse cloud and virtual environments, including its strong support for AI workloads and traditional VMs.

These consistent acknowledgments from top industry analysts affirm Red Hat's position as a trusted and leading provider of enterprise open-source software solutions, particularly in hybrid cloud, containers, automation, and AI.

Analysis

E. Technology Vendors, Data Providers, and Networks

1. Ecosystem

CMS requires innovative, secure, and scalable solutions to effectively manage its extensive programs. Open source principles such as transparency, community collaboration, flexibility, and cost-effectiveness align closely with CMS's goals for accountability, operational efficiency, and vendor independence. Red Hat delivers enterprise-grade open source platforms that provide the reliability, security, and scalability needed to meet these critical demands.

To stimulate developer interest in building digital health products for Medicare beneficiaries and caregivers, CMS can lead into both short-term and long-term actions, supported by Red Hat's open-source expertise and scalable platforms.

In the short term, CMS could focus on expanding developer-friendly tools and infrastructure. This includes providing production-representative FHIR APIs and secure sandboxes with realistic sample data to reduce barriers for digital health developers. Red Hat can assist by containerizing and orchestrating these environments using OpenShift to ensure scalability and ease of deployment. Additionally, CMS can accelerate adoption by offering open-source SDKs and reference applications for common Medicare use cases, such as chronic care management or Blue Button 2.0 access. Red Hat can contribute integration blueprints that leverage Red Hat Integration, Ansible Automation, and secure API frameworks. To further attract developer engagement, CMS could consider launching innovation challenges and pilot grants aimed at addressing underserved populations. These initiatives could be supported by cloud credits or compute grants in collaboration with cloud and open-source partners.

Red Hat can help by containerizing and scaling these environments with OpenShift and offering integration blueprints using Red Hat Integration, Ansible Automation, and secure API frameworks. For identity and consent, CMS could standardize on OAuth2 and FHIR, an area supported by Red Hat's identity solutions such as Keycloak and Red Hat SSO.

Looking ahead, CMS could work toward building a fully open, interoperable digital health ecosystem. One key initiative could be the creation of a CMS Developer Trust Framework, modeled after Trusted Exchange Framework and Common Agreement (TEFCA), that establishes interoperability, privacy, and security standards for third-party health apps. Additionally, CMS could modernize its architecture toward an event-driven model, enabling real-time data exchange via technologies like Kafka, webhooks, or FHIR Subscriptions. Red Hat's platforms support this evolution through OpenShift, Service Mesh, and GitOps workflows.

To streamline access and adoption, CMS could also establish a trusted Medicare App Directory or App Store, which would highlight compliant and beneficiary-friendly digital tools. Finally, with the rise of AI in healthcare, CMS could invest in infrastructure that supports explainable, auditable, and secure AI solutions. Red Hat offers AI/ML operations frameworks on OpenShift that align with transparency and reproducibility requirements in federal healthcare.

Red Hat Developer Hub plays a key role in unifying application and AI/ML development. As a centralized internal developer portal, it streamlines collaboration across diverse teams, accelerates onboarding, and simplifies access to documentation, templates, and toolchains. AI/ML engineers gain quick access to pipelines and environments, while app developers benefit from templates that seamlessly integrate AI models fostering a cohesive, efficient development lifecycle. Through self-service with built-in guardrails and a curated software catalog, Red Hat Developer Hub improves productivity while maintaining governance. This shared platform enhances understanding and accelerates delivery—especially critical when blending AI insights with traditional application workflows.

Red Hat is uniquely positioned to support CMS in both short- and long-term efforts through its leadership in open-source communities, its scalable hybrid cloud platforms, and its track record of supporting major federal healthcare agencies like the CMS, VA, DoD, and HHS. These combined capabilities can help CMS build a trusted, developer-friendly environment that accelerates innovation and improves outcomes for Medicare beneficiaries.

4. Data Exchange

TD-12. Should CMS endorse non-CMS data sources and networks, and if so, what criteria or metrics should CMS consider?

Red Hat OpenShift, as a leading enterprise-grade Kubernetes platform, empowers healthcare IT advancements by providing operational consistency and seamless interoperability. This allows organizations to focus on innovation rather than managing complex underlying infrastructure. For the Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS), prioritizing data sharing over traditional software licensing and data use agreements is crucial. This strategic shift prevents vendor lock-in and fosters increased collaboration among federal agencies and the private sector, ultimately ensuring that technological implementations directly align with the goals outlined in CMS's Federal Register postings. To effectively address the complexities of healthcare data, CMS could explore and integrate nascent technologies. Specifically, the combination of Knowledge Graphs and Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG), often referred to as GraphRAG, alongside Large Language Models, can revolutionize data interpretation and utilization. Furthermore, the implementation of Fast Healthcare Interoperability Resources (FHIR) standards, coupled with Red Hat AI, facilitates better contextualization and harmonization of data meaning. These sophisticated AI tools play a vital role in transforming heterogeneous, multimodal, and diverse healthcare data into standardized FHIR formats, ensuring reliable and semantically interoperable data exchange. This robust and integrated technological approach will enable CMS to build a resilient and forward-thinking health technology ecosystem.

TD-14. Regarding networks' use of FHIR APIs:

This proposed architecture outlines a highly effective strategy for deploying FHIR (Fast Healthcare Interoperability Resources) APIs within an enterprise healthcare environment, leveraging the robust capabilities of Red Hat technologies. At its foundation, the solution utilizes Red Hat OpenShift as the enterprise Kubernetes platform, providing a secure and scalable environment for containerized FHIR servers, such as Smile CDR or HAPI FHIR. This

deployment is seamlessly integrated with Red Hat AMQ Streams, based on Apache Kafka, to facilitate real-time data event processing and interoperability, a critical requirement for modern healthcare systems. Furthermore, API connectivity and management from Red Hat Integration is strategically positioned to govern and secure API access, ensuring controlled and auditable interactions with sensitive healthcare data, aligning with industry best practices for API lifecycle management.

The adoption of Red Hat's comprehensive platform delivers significant benefits for organizations seeking to manage FHIR APIs. OpenShift's inherent features provide unparalleled scalability and high availability, crucial for maintaining continuous access to patient data and supporting fluctuating demand. Its robust security features, including integrated identity management and network policies, are paramount for protecting sensitive health information. The platform's operational efficiencies, driven by OpenShift Operators for automated lifecycle management and integrated CI/CD pipelines, significantly reduce administrative overhead and accelerate development cycles. By standardizing on Red Hat's enterprise-grade solutions, organizations can achieve a resilient, compliant, and agile infrastructure for their FHIR APIs, enabling enhanced data exchange and innovation within the healthcare ecosystem.

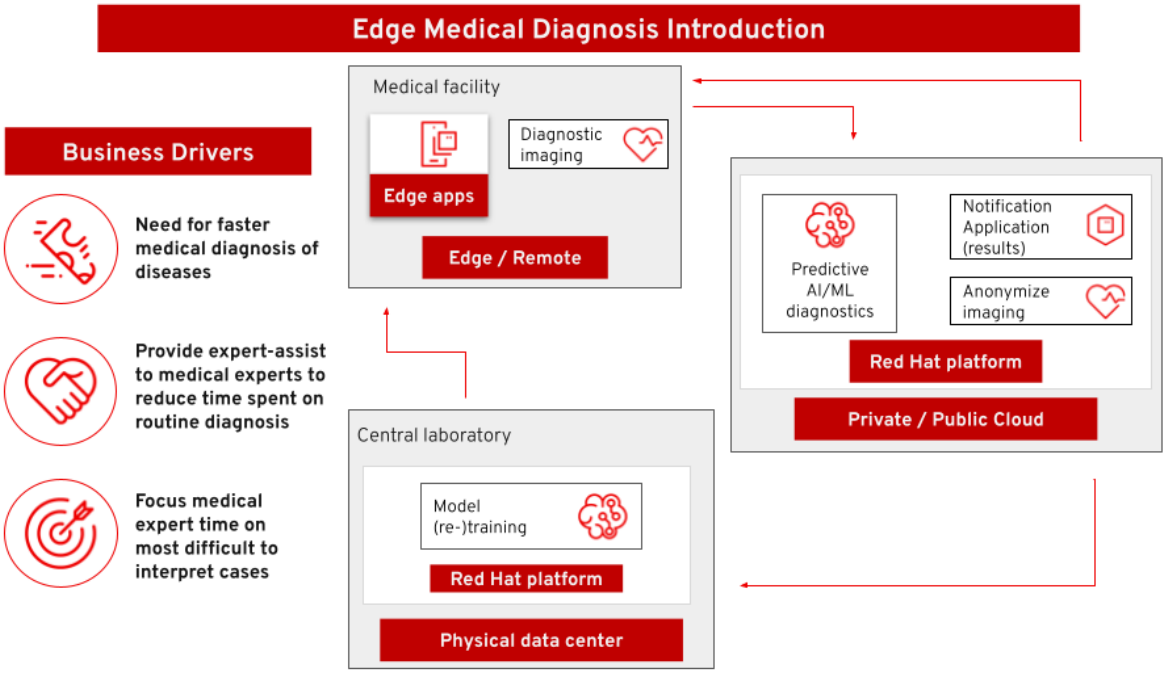

Figure 1. Overview of the Solution Reference Architecture

Recommendations

The health ecosystems across the U.S. are investing heavily in IT overhauls, with some spending hundreds of millions to modernize infrastructure, integrate acquisitions and streamline operations. According to 2023 data from Definitive Healthcare based on more than 5,000 U.S. hospitals, hospitals spent an average of $9.51 million on IT operating expenses, or 2.29% of their

total operating budgets. Spending scales significantly by facility size. Hospitals with 25 or fewer beds spent roughly $1 million, while those with more than 250 beds averaged more than $33 million.

The scope and cost of IT overhauls vary widely. Columbus, Ohio-based OhioHealth, for example, allocated $29.1 million to migrate newly acquired hospitals onto its Epic EHR platform, upgrade network infrastructure, and deploy Workday and Kronos platforms for operational and workforce management.

New Hyde Park, N.Y.-based Northwell Health, the largest health system in New York, is in the midst of a $1.2 billion IT overhaul to bring its entire enterprise onto a single instance of Epic—one of the nation's largest EHR transitions.

Meanwhile, Atlanta-based Emory Healthcare is investing $51 million in a modernized, integrated Epic EHR system following its acquisition of Warner Robins, Ga.-based Houston Healthcare.

For systems considering their next major IT shift, the range of investments across the industry underscores a key truth: **IT overhauls are no longer optional. But the scale, timing and cost structure must align with a system's size, strategy and long-term digital goals.**

AI is transforming healthcare delivery, yet many organizations struggle to harness its full potential. With 76% of health system leaders increasing AI investment to enhance patient satisfaction and operational efficiency, investing in AI infrastructure, model inference and agnostic cloud technologies is essential.[1]

What CMS chooses to do here, has an impact on the ecosystem of providers who have leveraged a huge technical debt, most making decisions based on FHIR and TEFCA standards. CMS could focus on the short and long term goals (short - two years out w/o change) and then the future 2+ years. CMS Blue Button 2.0 that utilizes a new version of the API, being introduced at the upcoming CMS 2025 - 07 FHIR Connectathon, will this announcement include AI strategies?

CMS could provide an ecosystem of open technologies to support and promote the collaborative goal of data sharing for the future. At the rate of technical adoption of AI, CMS could seek to leverage pilot programs in place with agencies and ARPA for models and data sharing technologies. Promote the runway for change on open source solutions where investments mean model inference savings for the future.

- Leverage Agentic AI to build a dynamic, interoperable national provider directory to enable intelligent, real-time data curation, validation, and integration across healthcare systems. The Red Hat AI Inference Server® harnesses the power of open source and the flexibility of hybrid cloud to deliver consistent, fast, and cost-effective models and can support these goals.

[1] https://go.beckershospitalreview.com/marketingwp/healthcare-ai-the-cure-for-patient-experience-challenges?utm_campaign=NICE_WP_April_2025&utm_source=email&utm_content=etextad&oly_enc_id=1215J4440378H4F

- By leveraging Red Hat Enterprise Linux 10's enhanced security, notably its post-quantum cryptography (PQC), directly benefits CMS by future-proofing sensitive data against quantum attacks and meeting federal mandates. Additionally, Red Hat Enterprise Linux 10's improved container security and AI-powered Lightspeed strengthen overall cybersecurity and streamline operations for CMS.
- Enhance and expand the functionality of CMS's Blue Button 2.0 patient access API by leveraging Red Hat Developer Hub to streamline API development, improve integration workflows, and accelerate secure, standards-based innovation.
- Accelerate the transition of CMS's Data at the Point of Care pilot to general availability by leveraging Red Hat OpenShift AI to enable intelligent data integration, real-time analytics, and scalable deployment across healthcare providers.
- Strengthen CMS's participation in trusted data exchange by utilizing Red Hat OpenShift AI Inference Server to enable secure, real-time decision support and scalable, policy-driven data sharing across healthcare networks.

Today, health data is gathered from many sources in varied formats, often without shared meaning across researchers, clinicians, and other users. Among many barriers, non-harmonized data hinders users from identifying best practices in data extract, transform, and load (ETL) or "cleaning" processes, research data uses, rapid development, care delivery science, and real-time clinical decisions. Rather than testing hypotheses, studying correlations, performing analyses, and deriving results, inordinate manual resources are devoted to ETL, mapping, and harmonization tasks to prepare data for analysis. This toil is not only costly, it requires third-party intervention, privacy risks, and produces additional barriers to novel RWE discovery. Across the federal government billions are spent each year mapping legacy EHR data with COTS systems in an effort to achieve Semantic Data Harmonization. CMS could explore agentic AI, RAG and Graph AI inferencing technologies to address some of these challenges.

Conclusion

In summary, Red Hat's enterprise open-source platforms, including Red Hat Enterprise Linux In summary, Red Hat's enterprise open-source platforms, including Red Hat Enterprise Linux and Red Hat OpenShift, and Red Hat OpenShift AI provide a robust foundation for secure, scalable digital health AI solutions. This, combined with Red Hat's recognized market leadership, compliance capabilities, and extensive industry acknowledgments, uniquely positions Red Hat to support CMS in its short and long-term goals.

Our solutions provide the complex underlying infrastructure support so that CMS can focus on:

- Data unification and enhanced interoperability that are critical for connected data and coordinated care. This necessitates the integration of data platforms and application programming interfaces to enable the secure and frictionless exchange of information across the healthcare ecosystem.

- A nationally consolidated provider directory to enhance healthcare access is needed. This authoritative and singular source for provider data aims to elevate data accuracy and alleviate provider burdens across the nation.
- For CMS, prioritizing data sharing over traditional software licensing and data use agreements is crucial. By leveraging its experience with major federal healthcare agencies and its commitment to open-source communities and hybrid cloud, Red Hat can significantly contribute to building a trusted, developer-friendly environment that fosters innovation and ultimately improves outcomes for Medicare beneficiaries.
- Red Hat specializes in hybrid cloud, containers, automation, and AI. With offerings like OpenShift AI and Red Hat Enterprise Linux AI, organizations can develop, deploy, and scale AI models using open standards, avoiding vendor lock-in. Red Hat integrates performance-optimized tools, such as Red Hat AI Inference Server and RAG, ensuring efficient, secure, and adaptable AI workloads. Red Hat AI Inference Server optimizes deep learning models for CPUs, eliminating the need for costly GPUs and providing high-throughput, low-latency inference for various environments. Any model, any accelerator, any cloud.
- Red Hat Enterprise Linux 10 significantly boosts security, with a strong focus on post-quantum cryptography (PQC). This helps future-proof sensitive data against potential quantum attacks and aligns with federal security mandates. Beyond PQC, Red Hat Enterprise Linux 10 also offers improved container security and AI-powered Lightspeed for better system management, strengthening overall cybersecurity and operational efficiency for organizations like CMS.
- Red Hat's enterprise open source platforms, including Red Hat Enterprise Linux and Red Hat OpenShift, enable secure, scalable digital health solutions, IT transformations, legacy system modernization, and the development of AI applications for patient care and data management across all cloud environments, inclusive of Oracle, Google, AWS, and Azure. This enables CMS to leverage Red Hat's Neural Magic for agnostic inferencing navigation for ultimate scale and savings to CMS and tax payers, while avoiding vendor lock-in and potential budget busters.
- Red Hat OpenShift, an enterprise Kubernetes platform, offers a secure, scalable environment for containerized FHIR servers (e.g., Smile CDR, HAPI FHIR). Integrated with Red Hat AMQ Streams (Apache Kafka), it enables real-time data event processing and interoperability, vital for modern healthcare systems.
- Red Hat offers CMS unparalleled support, both immediately and in the future, drawing on its leadership in open-source, robust hybrid cloud platforms, and demonstrated success with federal healthcare agencies, including CMS, VA, DoD, and HHS. By leveraging these capabilities, CMS can establish a secure and developer-centric environment that fosters rapid innovation and enhances the experiences of Medicare beneficiaries.

Red Hat is committed to not only near term goals but also the CMS' broader modernization agenda to accelerate digital health innovation, strengthen data security, enhance program integrity, and drive operational efficiencies across Medicare, Medicaid, and federal marketplaces, while promoting open collaboration and avoiding data, model and access "lock-in".